

common money pits, but of any and all continuing costs involved with products and services you buy into. Cars are costly and voracious, and some people simply opt to go without. But that's not possible for many people.

Owning a car, however, doesn't mean we can't be financially smarter about them. Do you really need the tinted windows, the fancy rims, the extended warranties, the heated seats, and the sunroof? Probably not. The goal of every good marketer is to make you fall in love with a big purchase so that every single incremental cost associated with that purchase feels vital and necessary. But car extras add up to thousands of dollars. And if you're thinking about resale, the only things people look for in terms of extras are air-conditioning and a decent stereo system. Most people will take low mileage over racing stripes any day. Also, don't accept the sticker price of a vehicle, especially a used one. Shop around, compare prices, and bring lower ones in writing to the dealership. And play hardball. Dealers want to move cars. The first price is never the final price.

Same goes for insurance. Shop around. Fees vary wildly from company to company, and if you have a clean driving history, you should be able to negotiate a better price. And don't go crazy on insurance. If you're driving an older vehicle whose resale value is less of a concern, skip collision coverage. So what if someone dings your car? It's often cheaper for you to pay for that out of pocket than to pay the insurance costs over time. If you are concerned about your car's appearance, then keep collision for a few years, but once it's past the point of a meaningful resale value, drop it.

Your other option is to move downtown. Or, if you live in a suburb, move to a city. Again, you can still keep your car for big grocery runs or dropping the kids off at the arena at dawn. But city dwellers tend to walk everywhere, and after paying \$20 a day for parking, you might be inclined to commute to work on foot. Never a bad idea. And buy a home near all the amenities you need. No use being near a grocery store, but far from the nearest dry cleaner or vet. Be strategic. What constitutes an amenity for you might not be necessary for someone else. Whatever you need your car for, buy near those shops and services and watch your savings grow. The cost of